full moment between the end of the heavy flow and the beginning of the shake, he paused. He looked around, his quiet prick in his hand, his head hot and stung with pollen, and felt the field gather itself around him, and the road alongside, and the dead shed down another hundred yards to the east. You could look all around, and there was not a building but the shed and not a human being but himself for as far as he could see. He could not remember ever being in such a place before.

After shaking he replaced himself into his clothing, tucked his shirt in and rolled up his sleeves. Too dizzy for the car just yet, he stood and stared at the shed, smoking and feeling that somehow, because of some perfect match between the dry field and his cigarettes, the thick, white smoke was letting him smell the grassy air more clearly. It was part of his success, part of the sweet achievement of being here; the two smells mixed into the one smell, which had instantly become, for him, the smell of this moment of life; it was his escape from his job, his freedom from the giant lie of his job.

Sales itself was a pleasure. Sales itself, he felt as he went back there in his mind, brought a sweet flush of relief as a closing would well up from below, because you felt the guy coming around before he knew it. You felt the slowly sweeping spiral of your pitch, pulled by a thin silver thread of the truth, as you turned through the old curve of the product's virtues and endearing quirks from every station of utility and status and convenience and design until the conversation closed in and snapped shut on a price. You made the price, sculpted it out of cost and tax and leeway and discount and stroke, with Intuition yapping at your heels as you felt the guy out. You had to Fear-of-Loss him. You had to Hope-of-Gain him. You had to Wipe-Away-Objection. And you had to be a Rhino, because that Rhino keeps coming on and on.

Sometimes it's just a Bystander-Potential-Customer, a B.P.C., some innocent stranger who has chanced to pause before the *RealValue* display window to tie his shoes for the minute and a half it takes him to notice the pliers sets. Miro has hooked them again and again, loping out the door as if for a cigarette break, asking the poor guy for a light, and falling to the praise of these immaculate, matched tools emblazoned with the manufacturer's arcane insignia, a white rhinoceros on a sable field, warding off the competition. They are the best ever made. Titanium.

And so between that ongoing mad zeal at the shop and the contract for eighty pieces he had hit at the Expo in Totowa, Miro became the sole eligible recipient of the *RealValue* Employee of the Year award, cash bonus one thousand but a god

damned two-day vacation to spend it in. To hell with them, in that case. He had given them the best years of his life; he was already twenty-five; it was enough.

News of his quitting would send a sharp little ripple of surprise through whatever lofty strata of the *RealValue* leadership it reached. That an award-winning go-getter—a sale-chaser, a Rhino—would win a bonus and then walk away with the cash, was unusual to say the least. That he should now be smoking these incredibly strong smokes (recommended by the nice hick at the Getty station) and standing in the middle of a wild tractor graveyard hundreds of miles from Queens, was even more unusual. It brought on a deeply calm feeling, something he half-remembered from the weekends he spent playing in the vacant lot on his father's block, long before the job, before high school even: the magical feeling that nobody knew where he was or what he was doing. People had been around then, walking by, and sometimes there was somebody on the stoop across the street, but in the lot? Never! The lot itself was his; gravel, bottles, pigeons, and the air that reached to heaven, all belonged to the tiny king, Miro. His blue ball bounced into the sky and down again, forever.

He took another drag and set off toward the shed, thinking of the blond and desiccated grasses, how they looked like wheat but were not. And you couldn't eat this grass; no, the cavemen that first started growing wheat must have had a hell of a time. We owe them all this, hazard lights and Pall Malls and *RealValue*, for the foraging around they did, that led to all this. Led to us.

When Doreen sat in his lap and the two of them looked at their reflection in the dark window of the bright laundromat, waiting for their clothes, he had thought, we are the evolved people. We are modern humans, me and Doreen. He thought of those ascending centerfold drawings that went from *Picanthropus* all the way up through *Cro-Magnon*, and imagined this reflection of him, severe, angry, beautiful, and Doreen on his lap with her smooth brow and smiling full lips that refused to be serious, even for a second, and never the right second—he imagined them as the last picture in the series. From *Australopithecus* to Doreen, it was a long way. A lot of campfires, a lot of teeth fallen out, a lot of getting rained on. And a lot of fucking in different kinds of weather, with the light changing all the time and the babies either dying or growing up too fast and one day laughing for no reason while wandering down the mountainside so that the parents thought, my God, the kid is a person already.

Doreen's breasts were little cones. She was ashamed of them, had a real problem with herself about it, and Miro had been unable to fix this though he tried